Nocturnes and Preludes (Or Regret in B Minor)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/21060476.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Lonnie/Scorpia (She-Ra), Kyle/Rogelio (She-Ra) (not really focused on but it's there)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra) (mentioned)

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Other Horde kids mentioned, Alternate Universe - Rock Band, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Catra and the other hybrids are still furries, because i make the rules, Speculation on Magicat culture, One unforgivable pun, Catra has access to therapy, But she's still CATRA, Also Micah is her therapist, "Mal is this au an excuse to imagine Catradora singing your favorite songs?", Yes., Rated T for Catra's (my) bad language

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Part 1 of Rhythm & Blues (C'mon, Darlin', Make Some Noise)

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by MalachiWalker

Summary

Fresh off a six month tour with her band, up-and-coming rock star Catra Leandros wakes up from yet another nightmare in a lifetime full of them and tries to at least make some music out of the lemons her psyche keeps throwing at her. But the phantoms of a life she never lived, a mistake she never made, and the ghost of the girl she walked away from ten years earlier are set on making that *extra* difficult. At least her crew (and their cat) have her back.

Or the Catradora rock star au that no one asked for.

Notes

This... Kinda came out of nowhere. I mean, I had a general plan and outline for the rock star au in my head, but I was much farther along with my planned pre-s4 Catradora redemption au fic than the silly, light hearted story I specifically created to take the edge off the angst. I guess I hecked up. But be on the lookout for that anyway. ;)

Just some quick stuff to know before getting started: Catra's band is an indie hard rock band called No Plan B, with Lonnie as the official leader, keyboardist and occasional death growl vocalist, Scorpia on the drums, Rogelio on bass, and Catra as the lead singer/lead guitarist, with Kyle as their roadie and Rogelio's bf. They're all in their late 20s now, and due to reasons that will be elaborated on in later fics, they've only just really hit the big time after six years of work. Meanwhile, Adora, Glimmer and Bow are a pop group called BFS that got signed to Bright Moon Records (run by Angella, natch) almost straight out of college and are very well known. This is an

Etheria of our technology level, but shaped by hybrids in addition to more humanoid species. Also, Catra's last name is Leandros mostly for the lion allusions because that's rad.

Anyway, enjoy.

See the end of the work for more notes

"I didn't break the world!"

A face more familiar than her own in the mirror, shaking her head and looking down at her. Cold rock under her palms, the white hot, phantom pain emptiness of bits and pieces of her body that were no longer there.

'Why is this happening?'

"But I am gonna fix it. And you... You made your choice."

A scream she doesn't want to make forces itself from her throat, distorted and wild as she lunges forward. It's sloppy, instinctive. She's always known bad things happen when her feelings get the better of her.

The voice she knows better than any other goes hot with anger, and she barely has time to register the arm drawing back as she closes the distance.

"Now live with it!"

Adora's fist comes crashing home.

Soaked in sweat and still reeling from the punch that shattered the world, Catra Leandros jerked awake in her Bright Moon flat, shaking and alone. The half-moon cast the room in blues and shadows from where it filtered in through the glass doors that comprised a large portion of the one room apartment's southern wall. The realtor had assured her that the glass was sturdy and the style all the rage; at the time, Catra had merely thought that it was just an excuse to drive the rental price even higher.

Now, sitting in a pool of her own sweat, black silk sheets plastered to her body in an uncomfortable embrace, Catra wanted to kiss whatever jackass had decided massive transparent doors were the latest and greatest way to show off wealth. Because even though magicats were blessed with night-sight, being able to tell in a

glance that she was alone did wonders for the rat-a-tat pounding of her heart.

Kicking the sheet away and swinging her legs over the edge of her bed, she planted her feet on the carpet and began to breathe slowly. In and out, just like her therapist Micah had taught her: four in, hold for seven, eight out. Slowly, the fight-or-flight panic began to leech out of her system, leaving her shaken—and shaking—but no longer ready to jump out of her own skin.

Another night terror. Great. She huffed a sigh, running a shaky hand through her mane.

It wasn't like Catra was a stranger to this scenario. In fact, her and this *exact damn awful situation* were practically lifelong friends at this point: the nightmares had started hard and fast when she was five years old after her parents' deaths and even now, twenty-three years and over half a decade of extensive therapy down the line, nobody had figured out how to make them stop. By now, Catra had more or less accepted that the dreams were just another part of her life—like the scars on her left hand that nearly wrecked her career, or the notch in her ear she'd gotten in a bar fight she'd been way too young to be in.

Didn't mean it made it any easier to see Adora—good-hearted, stupidly naive, playful *Adora*—glaring daggers at her as she wound up and socked Catra's lights out. And it definitely didn't help that the dreams of the last decade had made it perfectly clear that Catra—or at least dream Catra—had fully earned that disdain.

"Catra, while it <u>is</u> unusual for dreams to follow such a consistent narrative structure as yours, the life you see in your dreams is not your own. You are not living out your dream. You can learn from it's events if they help you, but letting them drive you through fear is a maladaptive response. You need to push through this."

Another Micah-ism. Now that she and the rest of the band were back at home after six non-stop months of touring, she'd need to

schedule an appointment. Regular phone calls on the road were all well and good, but no substitute for an actual sit down, "let's talk about your trauma" therapy session.

No Plan B would be closing out their tour next week at the smaller of Bright Moon's two arenas (not that the size of the place mattered, not when she and her crew had spent seven long years fighting their way to the top and had severed the brakes long ago.) Once that was done, they planned to take a well-deserved two month rest before getting back in the studio for their third album, and in the meantime Catra could focus on getting her emotional shit together.

Until then, she'd deal with her problems the same way she always had.

After running a shaky claw through her sweat-stained locks one more time to ground herself, she turned on the bedside lamp and grabbed the notepad and pen she kept there for just that reason. After flipping to a new page of blank sheet music, she set it aside with the pen on top and reached for her guitar.

Anybody who knew her would say her electric guitar was her pride and joy; sleek lines of red and black, (or what she'd been told was red, it just looked grey and black to her) with an extra wide fret board to accommodate her claws and a sound that easily alternated between the hum of contentment and the shrieks of the void tearing itself apart. And it was true that finally getting to purchase a Les Paw of her very own had been one of the proudest moments of her entire life, after years and years of severed strings and bleeding fingers from guitars that had never been made for magicat hands. To finally own a guitar from THE premier magicat brand had been a dream come true.

But as much as she loved that guitar, it was the one that sat on the stand beside her bed that truly owned Catra's heart. A simple acoustic, a little beat up and worn, but every nick and scratch told a story. It looked like any guitar that you could pick up in any store in the world, but the scars lent it character.

The only thing that would tip people off that there was something special about this guitar was the bridge, which obviously wasn't the original, as hinted by the faded outline of where the original part had rested creeping beyond the replacement's edges. And unlike the classic black plastic or wooden bridge that commonly adorned acoustics, this one was made of ivory white *bone,* the edges worn smooth from years of rubbing against the inside of Catra's leather jacket or the bottom of her rucksack.

Her left hand *ached.*

"Enough." Catra whispered to herself, even as a hard echo of *"Now live with it"* rattled against the insides of her brain like candy in the world's shittiest gumball machine. She needed to get out of her head, focus on something other than the tide of undeserved *grief* pounding against the crack in her heart.

Adora wasn't here. Catra hadn't burned the world to spite her, hadn't tried to lock her down between Catra's emotional gravity and her dreams. In this life—if that's what the dreams even were—when Catra had been given the option to tear it all apart, she'd done the right thing. She'd done what the other her in her nightmares should have done from the start.

She let Adora go.

Then why does it hurt so <u>much</u>?

"Let it go. Just let it all out." She murmured comfortingly to herself, the same way she barely remembered her mother doing whenever she got upset as a kit, while her fingers plucked experimentally at the strings, letting the music come as it would. The music would take shape in its own time, as it always did.

She found her rhythm, and picked up her pen in her left hand (what she had once called her "good hand," though the words just made her cringe now.)

As Catra jotted notes across the page and mouthed lyrics to herself, testing the way they felt on her tongue, her mind

wandered to the rest of her bandmates and what they might be doing—though a quick glance at the clock told her that trying to find out would be a bad idea. Texting the group chat at 2:37 AM was generally frowned upon in polite society.

Not that Catra gave a flying fuck what polite society thought of her—she wouldn't be a rock star if she did. But she *did* give a shit about her crew, and just because she was sleepless and miserable in her apartment didn't mean she had to pass it along to them like the world's worst game of hot potato.

There had been a time in her life when thoughts like that wouldn't even have occurred to her. But then again, a good chunk of that life she wouldn't have needed to: because the instant that the thrashing stopped Adora would already be tugging her into a half-conscious embrace in the safety of their shared bed, humming softly while her fingernails scratched at the base of Catra's ears, until her tail stopped sweeping back and forth and her whimpers settled down, reluctant purrs singing counterpoint to Adora's own heartbeat.

"Live with it."

"Fuck me blind, isn't that what I've been doing all this time?" Catra snarled in frustration as she set the guitar against the other pillow and retracted her claws so she could massage circles into her temples. Getting out of her head was clearly going to be a lot harder than usual tonight.

It was probably the fact that BFS had put out a new single that was all the rage on the pop and alt-rock charts, because even now half the time the DJs never knew exactly where to categorize them, especially on the occasions where a single veered away from their traditional light-and-airy sound.

The one, immutable rule that No Plan B had agreed on when they started out was this: whoever drove the tour bus got to pick the music. No complaints, and no whining unless you were willing to take the wheel yourself. And Scorpia, bless her heart, liked pop

music a bit more than most people would expect from the drummer in a hard rock band.

Of course, given Scorpia's nature, most people were ultimately more surprised that she was *in* a rock band to begin with.

But the point still stood, and that meant that for the past month Catra had been regularly greeted with the voice of her ex-best everything radiating out from the speakers at least once every hour.

I'm here in search of your glory/There's been a million before me/That ultra-kind of love you never walk away from/You're just the last of the real ones!

It was probably arrogance on her part, assuming that the song was for her. But still... Adora had no idea how much Catra's lungs ached to cry out, "I'm here! I'm right here! I've been singing for you all this time," how much her hands *yearned* to pull silverspun cords from her wailing guitar and show the whole damn world how much her heart still burned for that beautiful girl with her golden heart and steel-cord spine.

But Catra had walked away, at least in this life. And she *had* to live with that, no matter how much hearing that voice on the radio made her shake.

At least Lonnie and Rogelio were sympathetic to her plight, the former usually shooting her a "Sorry, bud" look across the tour bus and tossing her a pair of headphones and the latter stoically keeping the radio tuned to either classic rock or jazz standards whenever it was his turn to drive.

And Catra *got* it, really. Trying to stay upset at Scorpia was like trying to stay angry at a particularly huge, lovable puppy with claws, and while she knew from band discussions that Catra had a Complicated™ history with Adora... She wouldn't really understand *why* hearing that song felt like a knife lodging between Catra’s ribs every time it came on. Throw in the fact that

Lonnie and Scorpia had been dating for like two years on top of all that, and Catra had absolutely no desire to rock that particular boat.

So she sucked it up and dealt with it.

At least she could usually count on Kyle to take over the drive after Scorpia. While his own time in therapy had greatly assisted in calming his anxiety disorder (and spending most of both his work and home life side by side with Rogelio helped steady him even more) he was still fairly sensitive to discomfort, both in himself and others. Catra had lost count of how many times she'd bought him a Sprite or candy bar during a rest stop in the past month as a silent "Thank you" for his efforts.

But that still left her with a problem. How were you supposed to put to rest a ghost that you never truly let die?

Her phone chirped a notification on the bedside table, momentarily jolting Catra out of her thoughts.

Speak of the devil, she thought as she thumbed the lock screen open to see a new picture in the group chat. Scorpia, looking fantastic in a swanky black dress, stood with a brawny arm wrapped around each of her mothers, all three of them smiling exuberantly at the camera. Behind them, she could see the distinctive shape of the world famous Solace Opera House.

Nice, was all that came to mind as she thumbed down to pull up the keyboard, wishing that touch screen technology had progressed far enough to recognize that not everyone on the planet had fleshy, clawless fingers.

Catra
Having fun with your moms, I take it?

Scorps
Yes, as a matter of fact! And Wildcat!!! D: What are you doing up? It's like three am over there!

Catra
3:20 if you wanna get specific. And do you really wanna ask that question after you were texting the group chat at asshole o'clock in the morning?

Scorps
First of all, it's not three am where I am.

Scorps
Secondly, I just put it in the group chat so you guys could see it when you woke up naturally.

Scorps
And thirdly, I KNOW how low you set your ringtone. If you weren't already awake, we wouldn't be talking.

Damn. She had Catra there. It was hard keeping secrets from someone who had just spent six months with you crammed in close quarters in what was—although admittedly a pretty nice one—*still* a glorified mobile tin can.

Catra
Ok yeah, I'm not even gonna try to weasel out of this one. I was already awake.

Scorps
The nightmares again? :(

Catra
Yeah, but it's not SO bad. Just doing my usual "channel it into music" thing.

Scorps
Is Star there with you?

Catra's lips quirked upwards in an involuntary smile at the mention of the group's unofficial mascot/shared son, a white furred, blue eyed cat Scorpia had found beside a motel dumpster somewhere in bumfuck Aridzona a year and a half earlier. She'd spent nearly thirty minutes trying to coax him into approaching until Catra had

finally come looking for her and quickly pinpointed the problem: like most cats with that particular combination of genes, he was completely deaf.

Once they realized that, the pair had managed to get the juvenile feline to cuddle up to them most ricky-tick, and when Lonnie came looking for them the combination of her girlfriend's puppy dog eyes and Catra's utter refusal to help her be the adult had resulted in the situation they had today: where Star spent part of the year as their "roadcat" and the rest of the time hopping between the band members' individual homes on a weekly basis.

Catra
No, the boyson is not with me. I let Lonnie have him this week. Figured she'd want the company with her gf halfway around the world, even if she's too stubborn to admit it. ;p

Scorps
Awww, that's really sweet of you. I'll be home soon!

Scorps
But I am kinda sorry he isn't there. I know how much he helps with the nightmares.

Catra
Yeah...

Like she'd just noted, it was pretty hard to keep secrets from the people that shared a sardine can with you. So even though Scorpia hadn't been at the Fright Zone with the rest of them, she'd still had multiple experiences with Catra's night terrors. She was even pretty sure they had a rotating schedule between the four of them to decide who checked on her—though obviously none of them would confirm that suspicion for fear of making Catra uncomfortable. At least, not any more so than her fucked up psyche already made her.

Star's presence on the tour bus didn't make the nightmares any less frequent, but the group had discovered—to their collective

relief—that it was a lot easier for Catra to calm down afterward when there was a ten pound ball of fluff and unconditional affection purring away atop her chest.

Catra
Look, it's fine. Lonnie needed him this week and I've got my acoustic and pen and paper. Once we finish out the tour next Friday I'll schedule an appointment with Micah.

Scorps
Tell you what. Schedule the appointment at whatever awful hour you wake up this afternoon AFTER you finally pass out, and I won't give you any more grief.

Catra
… And what happens if I refuse?

Scorps
I call my girlfriend. Right now. :)

Fuck.

Catra
Ok, ok, I promise. Now will you PLEASE go have fun with your moms? You're at the Solace Opera House, for fuck's sake. Shouldn't you be paying attention and soaking in the refinement or something?

Scorps
That's what the orchestra’s warm-up period is for, Wildcat. But I'll talk to you tomorrow!

Scorps
Also, my moms said "Hi." And want me to tell you to eat better.

Catra
And how would they know my eating habits, hmm???

Catra
Later.

Amazing what a mere twenty four minutes could do, both in terms of lifting her mood and tiring her out. Returning her phone to its charger, Catra glanced between the old guitar and the half-finished notes on her lap.

Part of her just wanted to give in to sleep, call it a night. The other part of her... Well, it was a simple fact that a lot of her best songs were born in these solitary writing sessions, and she was off to a pretty good start...

"This is all your fault!" Her dream self, voice distorted by corruption and rage, still snarled in her ears.

And then the simple, quiet answer that had shattered her entire world for ten long, *agonizing* years. *"You made your choice. Now live with it."*

She was still working when the sun came up.

I roam these halls, search the night
In hopes that I may see
A remnant trace, a glimpse of you
I stare into the deep
Singing, "I know, I know, I know, I know, I know
I know my love can be..."
The deep stares back, speaks to me,
I know my love can be
The killing kind.

End Notes

I want you all to know I'm sorry for the Les Paw guitar pun. And Aridzona. And that I wish I could promise there won't be more terrible puns in the future. Have mercy on my soul.

Adora's song is "Last of the Real Ones" by Fall Out Boy. The song Catra works on post-nightmare is "The Killing Kind" by Marianas Trench off their album, Phantoms, which I highly recommend checking out because it is a HUGE post s3 mood.

Anyway, this is just supposed to be a prelude to set the stage for the au proper... a prelude that got away from me for four hours. Can't tell you when the next chapter will be here, but I can say that next time we'll be seeing what Adora and the Best Friends Squad have been up to and getting a bigger glimpse into this world, where things have changed and where they've stayed the same.* And we'll get to see Catra and crew being actual rock stars. Hope you'll join me for that, and please leave a review or kudos if you enjoyed.

*Hint: Shadow Weaver's still an A+ parent.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!